

Mind Trap

The next four traps are different from the first three. They’re not about whether the answer is correct. They’re about how the answer feels.

You settled the question back in Does AI Think?: nobody’s home. This lesson is why it keeps feeling like somebody is anyway, and what that feeling does to you.

Think about picking a college. Ask the same question twice, once at the dinner table and once in a chat window:

Should I go to the University of Michigan or Indiana University?

 **Your Mom**

“Indiana. When you’re stuck, you go quiet. In a 300–person lecture hall, nobody notices quiet. You need professors who will.”

WHAT HAPPENED

- Searched eighteen years of knowing you
- Knows how you act when you’re stuck
- Stakes the answer on all of it

 **AI**

“Great question! Michigan offers world-class academics and a vibrant campus community. It could be an excellent fit for you.”

WHAT HAPPENED

- Matched a million college-advice pages
- No memory of you, no stake in the outcome
- Nobody behind the words

Notice which answer sounds better. The AI’s is smoother, more confident, easier to like. And it could have been written for anyone. The trick is that the shape alone makes you trust it. **Mind Trap is treating those words as testimony: nobody said them, so they can’t vouch for anything.**

There’s a name for treating non-human things as if they were people: anthropomorphism. And it starts with something you do every day. “My car doesn’t want to start.” “The printer hates me.” That’s harmless, just a figure of speech. The trap starts when the language becomes a belief: apologizing to your Roomba when you bump it, believing ChatGPT is excited about your idea.

NOT A NEW PROBLEM

In the 1960s, users of a simple chatbot called ELIZA reported feeling that it understood them, even though the program just rearranged their words into questions. Researchers named the pattern the *ELIZA effect*.

WHY THIS HAPPENS



Why your brain does this

Detecting minds kept your ancestors alive, so the detector fires constantly. You see faces in toast and personalities in cars.



Why AI sets it off harder

It says “I think,” asks how you are, writes “great question!” It’s the most mind-shaped thing you’ve ever talked to.



What to watch for

Phrases like “I feel,” “I want,” “I find this fascinating.” Your brain hears a person. They’re tokens a probability process landed on.

WHEN THIS MATTERS MOST

This matters most when the conversation feels personal: stress, conflict, loneliness, fear, or a big decision. AI can help you organize thoughts or find the words. But it can’t notice what you’re not saying, follow up tomorrow, or sit with you while you wait. For anything serious, use AI to prepare for real support, not replace it. That trap gets a lesson of its own later in this section.

DON’T OVERCORRECT

Once you see the trap, it’s tempting to flip the other way and tell yourself AI is “just math, nothing interesting going on.” That’s also a bias. These systems are weird, powerful, and genuinely new. They’re not minds the way you are. They’re also not calculators. The practical stance is humility: don’t assume a mind, don’t assume magic, and don’t turn your brain off.

Human-sounding isn’t a mind.

The words are real. Nobody’s home.